CHEAT SHEET

Cheat sheet

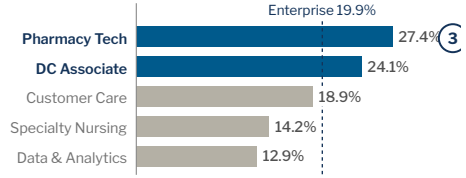
Check before you send

- [ ] The headline is an insight, and every number in it is true
- [ ] Subtitle: metric, unit, scope and period
- [ ] Grey context; at most 2 highlights, matching the headline
- [ ] Values labelled; value axis, gridlines and legend deleted
- [ ] Bars start at zero; no dual axes
- [ ] Sorted by value, or in a natural order
- [ ] True minus (−), explicit + on changes, "pts" for point changes
- [ ] Metric defined; source names system, date and population
- [ ] No group under **10 people**, even in hover text
- [ ] Nothing overlaps or clips; nothing below 9 pt

1 · EVERY CHART, ONE ANATOMY

Two frontline job families lose about 1 in 4 people a year, well above the 19.9% enterprise rate ①

Voluntary attrition by job family, FY26 (%) ②



Source: Workday HCM (synthetic), FY26 ④

① Headline = the insight · ② Subtitle = the measure · ③ Grey context, blue focus, values on the bars · ④ Source

2 · WRITE THE HEADLINE LAST

Who or what + verb + number + so what. Compute every number from the data.

LABEL	Attrition by job family
VAGUE	Attrition varies across job families
INSIGHT	Two frontline job families lose about 1 in 4 people a year

3 · GREY FIRST, THEN COLOR THE POINT

Context everything else	`#B4B0A5`
Focus what the headline names	`#005A8C`
Accent (navy) the one exception	`#143359`
Light blue a series, in the uniform pattern	`#66C4FF`
Orange worse only: below target, shrinking	`#EF8200`
Total totals, targets (dashed)	`#143359`

At most 2 highlights. Orange never highlights; it means worse. Amber is never used.

4 · TYPE (LIBRE FRANKLIN, 16:9 SLIDE)

Slide title	Bold	24 pt
Chart headline	SemiBold	18 pt
Subtitle	Regular	14 pt
Data labels	Medium	12 pt
Axis, categories	Regular	11 pt
Footnote, source	Light	9 pt
Big number	Bold	54 pt

One chart: the slide title is its headline. Two charts: each gets its own SemiBold insight headline.

5 · PICK THE CHART FROM THE QUESTION

- How big? Sorted bar
- Made of what? 100% bar, waterfall
- Over time? Line
- Who moved? Slope, dumbbell
- How spread? Strip, histogram
- Related? Scatter
- Flows? Sankey · Where? Map
- One number? Big number

Full version: the chart chooser.

6 · NEVER

- Red vs. green, rainbows, or color as the only cue
- 3D, shadows, gradients, borders
- Truncated bars or dual axes
- A legend where labels fit
- More than 2 charts on a slide
- Pictures of charts: use native, editable charts